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THA 112: Comparative Traditions of World Theatres

Compare performance traditions without ranking them

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Comparison is a skill, not a list. This pack gives you a comparison grid covering space, performer training, text, audience and purpose, then applies it to African festival theatre, Greek theatre, Noh, Commedia dell'arte and contemporary Nigerian stage practice.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Construct a comparison grid for any two performance traditions.
- Describe Greek, Japanese and African traditions using accurate terminology.
- Explain how performer training and audience expectation differ across traditions.
- Avoid evolutionist language that treats one tradition as more advanced.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Compare on dimensions, not vibes

A comparison needs fixed criteria applied to both cases.

- Space: where does performance happen, and who can see whom?
- Text: is there a fixed script, an outline, or an inherited pattern?
- Performer: trained specialist, community member, or both?
- Audience: separated, participating, or paying customers?
- Purpose: civic competition, religious observance, entertainment or social critique?
- Transmission: school, apprenticeship, family lineage or mass media?

> **Do not write 'primitive'**
> Evolutionist language - primitive to sophisticated - is inaccurate and penalised. Say 'participatory' or 'text-centred' and define it.

Three traditions in brief

Know enough detail to support a comparison, not a full history.

- Greek: civic festival of Dionysus, masked actors, chorus, open-air amphitheatre, competition between playwrights.
- Japanese Noh: highly codified movement, masks, chant and a slow tempo; transmission through schools and lineages.
- African festival theatre: community participation, music and dance as structure, flexible performance space.
- Commedia dell'arte: professional troupes, stock characters, improvisation around a scenario, touring economy.
- Nigerian contemporary stage: blends festival elements, literary drama and popular theatre forms.

Writing the comparison answer

Structure carries the marks.

1. Introduce both traditions with dates and contexts.
2. State the criteria you will compare on.
3. Take one criterion at a time and discuss both cases.
4. Give a specific example for each claim.
5. Explain a similarity and a difference in function, not only in appearance.
6. Conclude with what the comparison reveals about theatre as a human practice.

Comparison is a method, not a survey

A comparative answer fails when it becomes two summaries placed next to each other. The fix is to state your criteria before you discuss either tradition, then move criterion by criterion across both cases. Six criteria carry almost every comparison question: the performance space, the status of the text, the training of the performer, the role of the audience, the purpose of the event, and how the tradition is transmitted to the next generation.

Worked properly, a comparison produces a finding rather than a list: for example, that Greek and Noh theatre both formalise performance through masks and inherited conventions, but distribute authority very differently - one through civic competition, the other through hereditary schools. That sentence is an argument; the surrounding detail is its evidence.

The other trap is evaluative language. Words like primitive, advanced, developed and authentic smuggle in a hierarchy that the evidence does not support. Replace them with descriptors: participatory or spectator-separated, text-centred or scenario-based, codified or improvisatory. Each descriptor can be demonstrated.

Three traditions worth knowing in detail

Greek theatre of the fifth century BCE was produced within a civic festival in honour of Dionysus. Three playwrights competed in tragedy, each presenting a tetralogy; a chorus of citizens performed; masks allowed three actors to play many roles; the open-air amphitheatre made scale and vocal projection central to the writing. Its conventions - the chorus, the messenger speech, the unities - are responses to that event, not abstract rules.

Japanese Noh, formalised by Zeami in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, is a theatre of extreme codification: a slow tempo, stylised gesture, masks for certain roles, chant and a small instrumental ensemble. Transmission runs through schools and lineages, so a performer's authority is institutional as well as personal. Comparing Noh with Greek practice shows how two masked, musical, convention-heavy theatres can produce entirely different audience experiences.

Commedia dell'arte, professional from the sixteenth century in Italy, reversed the emphasis: fixed masked types, a scenario rather than a full script, and improvisation within known "lazzi". It is the clearest case in world theatre of an economy shaping form - touring companies needed portable plots and repeatable characters rather than libraries of scripts.

> **One comparison, one finding**
> If your essay could be read as two separate essays stapled together, the comparison has not happened. Every paragraph must contain both cases.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 112

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 112 Comparative Traditions of World Theatres appears in the 2018 course descriptions
- The same page separates THA 113 Theatre History in Perspective: 500 BC - 1800 AD
- Descriptions emphasise comparison of world traditions rather than a single national history

What changed: THA 113 appears in the 2018 description but is absent from the 2019 programme listing, so the history sequence was reorganised.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 112 Comparative Traditions of World Theatres, 3 credits, second semester, 100 level
- Second-semester 100-level package includes THA 122, 132, 142, 152 and 162
- No THA 113 in this listing

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Comparative traditions remains a 100-level core in the compiled map
- Expect African, Asian and European traditions to be compared rather than surveyed separately
- Check whether your cohort takes this in first or second semester

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building the comparison grid

Question: compare the role of the audience in Greek theatre and in African festival performance.

1. State the criteria you will use: spatial relation, participation, and the source of authority over the event.
2. Greek case: the audience sits in a civic amphitheatre, separated but addressed; participation is indirect - judgement, applause, competition voting - and the festival authority is civic and religious.
3. Festival case: the audience is inside the performance area, participation is direct and sometimes required, and authority over the event rests with custodians and the ritual calendar.
4. Identify the similarity that matters: in both, attendance is a social act, not a consumer transaction.
5. Identify the difference that matters: Greek separation supports a fiction that the audience watches; festival participation supports an event the audience completes.
6. Conclude with the finding, not a summary: the audience is a compositional element in both, but one is addressed and the other is enrolled.

> **What to carry forward**
> Similarity and difference must both be explained in terms of function, not appearance.

2. Handling the word "authentic"

A question asks which of two traditions is "more authentic". This is a trap, and here is how to answer it without refusing the question.

1. Define authenticity in the sense the question implies: closeness to an original or unchanged form.
2. Show that both traditions have changed historically - Greek practice changed across the classical period; festival forms absorb new instruments, fabrics and media.
3. Argue that transmission is itself the tradition: what looks like change is often the mechanism by which a form survives.
4. Offer a usable substitute criterion: coherence with the community's own account of the form.
5. Answer the question on your own terms: neither is more authentic; each is authentic to a different mechanism of authority.

> **What to carry forward**
> Reject the premise, then answer a better version of the question. Refusing to answer scores nothing.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Compare two masked theatre traditions and explain what the mask does in each.

20 marks; criteria-led comparison

1. Name the two traditions and date them.
2. Greek: the mask as a practical device for role-doubling and vocal projection, and as a marker of character type.
3. Noh: the mask as a means of transforming the performer and fixing emotional register.
4. Compare on function, then on control: who decides when a mask is worn, and what does that say about authority?
5. Note what the mask makes impossible in each case (facial nuance, realism).
6. Conclude with a finding about convention and audience competence.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Describing two masks without ever saying what each one accomplishes.

Q2. Why is evolutionist language ("primitive to sophisticated") inadequate for comparative theatre study?

15 marks

1. Define evolutionism in this context: the assumption that theatre forms move through stages toward a European endpoint.
2. Show the empirical problem: participatory and codified forms are not earlier versions of realism; they are different solutions.
3. Show the conceptual problem: the hierarchy makes it impossible to describe what a form actually does.
4. Offer replacements: participatory/spectator-separated, codified/improvisatory, text-centred/scenario-based.
5. Illustrate with one tradition that the language would misdescribe.

Q3. What does a touring economy explain about commedia dell'arte?

15 marks

1. Describe the production conditions: travelling companies, limited props, unfamiliar audiences and languages.

2. Link form to conditions: stock masked types are instantly readable, scenarios travel better than scripts, lazzi can be reused.
3. Explain the cost: character depth and plot originality are traded for portability.
4. Compare with a settled repertory theatre where scripts accumulate.
5. Conclude that material conditions are part of dramaturgy, not background.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Comparative method. Analysis that applies fixed criteria to two or more cases in order to produce a finding rather than two summaries.

Noh. A Japanese masked theatre form of chant, dance and highly codified gesture, transmitted through schools.

Lazzi. Rehearsed comic routines inserted by commedia performers into a scenario.

Scenario. An outline of situations and characters from which performers improvise, rather than a fixed script.

Stock character. A recurring conventional figure whose traits the audience recognises immediately, such as the commedia miser or braggart.

Chorus (Greek). The group of citizen performers who sing, dance and comment, framing the action of a Greek play.

Amphitheatre. An open-air performance space with tiered seating around the acting area.

Codification. The process by which a performance tradition fixes gestures, tempos and roles into teachable rules.

Transmission. How a performance form is passed on, whether by family lineage, school, apprenticeship or written record.

Evolutionism. The mistaken assumption that cultural forms progress in stages toward a single advanced model.

Performance convention. An accepted shorthand that the audience agrees to read in a particular way.

Civic festival. A religious and political celebration funded and attended by the city, within which theatre is produced.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Grid

Build the instrument.

- Write the six comparison criteria in your own words.
- Fill the grid for two traditions you have studied.
- Identify one criterion where you need more evidence.

Week 2 - Detail

Know three traditions.

- Write one page each on Greek, Noh and commedia.
- Learn five terms specific to each.
- List what each tradition makes difficult.

Week 3 - Argument

Findings, not surveys.

- Draft a comparison with a stated finding.
- Check every paragraph mentions both cases.
- Remove every evolutionist word from the draft.

Week 4 - Exam

Timed comparison.

- Answer one comparison question in 35 minutes.
- Mark it against your own grid for coverage.
- Rewrite only the conclusion as a finding.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your departmental course outline for THA 112 and any set translations of Greek plays.
- A general theatre history chapter on classical Japanese theatre for Noh terminology.
- Any accessible introduction to commedia dell'arte covering scenarios and stock types.
- One scholarly article that compares two traditions - study how it states its criteria.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. List five dimensions for comparing performance traditions.

Answer: Space, text, performer training, audience role and purpose. Transmission is a sixth.

2. What makes Noh a useful comparison with Greek theatre?

Answer: Both use masks, highly formalised performance and inherited conventions, but differ in tempo, competition and religious framing.

3. Why is 'primitive theatre' an inaccurate phrase?

Answer: It imposes a false hierarchy of development and ignores the sophistication and function of participatory forms.

4. How does audience role differ between festival theatre and proscenium theatre?

Answer: Festival audiences participate and may be part of the performance; proscenium audiences are separated and typically observe.

5. What is a scenario in Commedia dell'arte?

Answer: An outline of situations and stock characters that performers develop through improvisation rather than a fixed script.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a comparison grid with six dimensions.
- [ ] Fill the grid for two traditions you have studied.
- [ ] Learn ten terms specific to non-European theatre.
- [ ] Watch a short Noh excerpt and note three conventions.
- [ ] Write a 400-word comparison with evidence for each claim.
- [ ] Remove every evolutionist phrase from your draft.
- [ ] Discuss your grid with a coursemate and add one dimension you missed.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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